ONE-OFF SHIURIM

The End of Days, Step by Step

Derech Hashem, Maamar HaIkarim

Sefer: Maamar HaIkarim by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal), printed at the end of Derech Hashem **Section:** Maamar HaIkarim, essay 8: redemption, the resurrection, the great day of judgment and the renewed world **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 7 July 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: two views of Mashiah

The world must come to a rectification. Besides our individual work, Israel has a collective responsibility, and when it is fulfilled Mashiah will come. If not, he will come of his own accord, as promised, by the end of the 6,000 years. The Ramhal paints a utopian picture in which everyone wants to serve God and the choice is between good and even better. The Rambam held that the only difference will be Israel's sovereignty, with free will between good and bad still in place.

Resurrection and the great day of judgment

Everyone who is alive must die and return to the earth before the resurrection, and then rise again. We are not told how long the gap between Mashiah and the resurrection will be.

Both the righteous and the wicked will rise. After the resurrection comes the great day of judgment, when God decides who will live on for eternity and who will perish. Perishing, as the group has learned many times, means simply ceasing to exist. Those who are fit will remain, each at his level, in the renewed world. In the Rabbi's stadium image, the question is how high up your seat is.

He pointed out why the judgment must come after the resurrection. In theory souls could be judged while the bodies are still in the grave. But it is the Ramhal's consistent philosophy that body and soul acted as a unit, so they must receive both the judgment and the result as a unit.

What we know and what we don't

The Ramhal does not mention Eliyahu or the Temple here. When will Eliyahu come? Before Mashiah, or together with him? When will the Temple be built? When will the war of Gog and Magog be? "I don't know. No one knows." There will be a period of upheaval, but the exact order cannot be known. What we know are principles:

- Olam HaBa, the renewed world, is the ultimate goal. Gan Eden and Gehinnom are not.

- There will be a special time of Mashiah in this world: for the Rambam, political sovereignty; for the Ramhal, much more.
- During this period there will be Eliyahu and the Temple.
- There will be a resurrection, followed by the great day of judgment, deciding who has a portion in the World to Come and who will perish.

A participant asked whether the yeser hara will be weakened. The Rabbi suggested we stop picturing it as two voices arguing inside us, as we teach children. It is really the pull between body and soul. The soul pulls us up: consciousness, empathy, the traits unique to humanity. The body pulls us down: selfishness, ego and lust, the things we share with other mammals. That pull will be removed, but the question will remain how much good each person pursues. Even now, he said, we always face that choice: we did the right thing, but could we have done even better?

The nations, and the Rambam on Christianity and Islam

The Ramhal says there will be a great selection among the nations at that time. Those without a portion in the World to Come will perish. Those fit to be saved will remain, recognise the truth, abandon their idols and serve God together with Israel, and it will be an honour for them, because through it they gain a share in holiness. The prophet says God will give the nations "a clear language". The Rabbi explained that this is not a single spoken language but a metaphor: everyone will be "on the same page", with the same goals. "On that day God will be one and His name one."

He added that in Olam HaBa itself there will of course be a portion for non-Jews who merit it. A non-Jew who keeps the seven Noahide laws has a portion in the World to Come.

A participant asked about a statement attributed to the Rambam that Christianity and Islam did something good. The Rabbi confirmed that the Rambam writes it clearly, about both. Of about 7.5 billion people, roughly four billion believe in one God, the God of Avraham, because of these religions. They brought the Torah, the Bible, and talk of the Messiah and the end of days to the masses. "In the grand scheme of things, for humanity as a whole, the Rambam is 100% right."

The world renewed

After the resurrection the world will return to nothingness, "like the beginning of creation". Meanwhile the righteous, meaning all who have a portion in the World to Come, will somehow continue to exist. The Rabbi admitted, "I've got no idea what this means. I've never understood this properly." The Gemara speaks of God giving them wings. They will not yet have the full good, which comes only after the world is renewed in its new form. Then they will enjoy the true good forever, each at his level, body and soul together.

He then ran through the whole sequence. This world is Olam HaZeh. A person who dies today goes to the world of souls, Gan Eden or Gehinnom, neither of which is the ultimate. Then come the days of Mashiah, with Eliyahu and the Temple. At some point, after a period of life in this world (not immediately), everyone will die. Then comes the resurrection, the great day of judgment, the end of those with no portion, and finally the world's period of nothingness and renewal into Olam HaBa.

Why care about the planet?

A participant asked: if the world is destined to end anyway, why bother about carbon emissions? The Rabbi said many people have said that to him, and he disagrees. Scientists warn of serious damage within decades, to coastal towns and to low-lying countries such as Tuvalu. More fundamentally, these calculations are not ours to make. "Our duty is to have a good world. That's all we need to care about."

Summary

- Everyone will pass through death and rise in the resurrection, and judgment will come to body and soul together.
- The exact order of Eliyahu, the Temple, Gog and Magog and the resurrection is unknown; only the principles are clear.
- Nations who recognise the truth will serve God with Israel, and the righteous of the nations have a portion in Olam HaBa.
- The world will return to nothingness and be renewed as Olam HaBa, the true and eternal good.
- The end of days is no excuse to neglect the world; our duty is to keep it good.

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